could go, there was no reason why a thousand could not. However, the DQ's assessment had been blindly repeated by so many that it had come to be seen as the gospel truth.

Division HQ's doubts were further reinforced when artillery guns tried to engage these groups. The Chinese had taken adequate precautions, having staggered the distances to avoid presenting a bunched target. Also, as the valley was deep, the field guns had to fire at a high angle and met with no obvious success. However, as the reports continued to come in, HQ 4 Division rather belatedly told 48 Brigade at Bomdila to move a company to reinforce the post at Poshing-la. By then it already was a case of too little too late.

On 13 November, a Chinese convoy was seen parked near the district commissioner's office. This clearly confirmed that the Chinese had indeed constructed the link road across Bum-la to Tawang. Again 4 Artillery Brigade tried to engage the target, but failed to do any real damage.

The brigade commander, Hoshiar Singh, was confident that when the main Chinese attack came, he could fight a self-contained battle even if he was cut off and isolated from the rear. Hoshiar Singh repeatedly let it be known to the rank and file that the brigade was going to stand its ground. With Indian patrols generally faring poorly against the Chinese, the brigade commander felt that the troops needed to do something that would boost morale. He announced that the brigade would give a cash award of Rs 1,000 to anyone who captured a Chinese soldier.

4 Garhwal Rifles had been in a supporting role to 1 Sikh in Bum-la. During the fallback from Tawang, Major H. B. Rai had been entrusted with holding Bridge 4, which many junior officers felt had been blown up prematurely the moment the Chinese mortars had opened up. According to all accounts, of all the battalions present on and around Se-la, it was the Garhwalis who had a spring in their step and a glint in the eye as the battalion prepared itself for the coming battle with some aggressive patrolling.

During the daylight hours of 13 November, a 4 Garhwal patrol under Second Lieutenant Vinod Kumar Goswami had moved into the Mago region under the cover of thick vegetation to observe Chinese movements around Rho. Towards the evening, twenty Chinese soldiers approached a hut near the north bank of the Mago Chu and it soon became apparent to the watching Garhwal patrol that the Chinese were settling in for the night.